

Chatbot vs. AI Agent

Notes on the difference between the two, and why the distinction actually matters.

Chatbot

Basically something you talk to. You send a message, it replies. It's good at conversation, but it doesn't really do anything beyond that conversation.

AI Agent

Something you give a goal to. It figures out the steps, uses tools or apps if it needs to, and actually gets the task done — not just talks about it.

Where they actually differ

Aspect	Chatbot	AI Agent
What it's for	Answering questions, chatting, pointing you to info	Getting an actual task done, start to finish
What it can touch	Just text — it can't step outside the chat window	Other tools and apps too, so it can take real actions
How it decides things	Picks a reply each turn, one exchange at a time	Plans out several steps ahead, then adjusts as it goes
Memory	Mostly just remembers the current chat	Can hold context across a longer task or multiple sessions
Who drives	You — it waits for you to say something	It can, once pointed at a goal, keep going on its own
Where you'd see it	A help-widgit on a website, a support FAQ bot	Something running research, bookings, or a workflow for you

The way I'd explain it

A **chatbot** is someone to talk to. An **AI agent** is someone you'd hand a task to and walk away. That's really the whole difference — talking vs. doing. A lot of tools today are actually both at once: they look like a chatbot on the surface, but underneath, there's an agent quietly doing the work.